

STATE OF NEW YORK

6360--A

2025-2026 Regular Sessions

IN SENATE

March 11, 2025

Introduced by Sens. HARCKHAM, COMRIE, SALAZAR -- read twice and ordered printed, and when printed to be committed to the Committee on Environmental Conservation -- committee discharged, bill amended, ordered reprinted as amended and recommitted to said committee

AN ACT to amend the environmental conservation law, in relation to clarifying provisions regarding the use of crossbows for hunting

The People of the State of New York, represented in Senate and Assembly, do enact as follows:

1 Section 1. Section 11-0103 of the environmental conservation law is
2 amended by adding a new subdivision 33 to read as follows:

3 33. "Long bow" includes longbows, recurve bows, compound bows, and
4 crossbows.

5 § 2. Subparagraph 9 of paragraph b of subdivision 4 of section 11-0901
6 of the environmental conservation law, as added by section 6 of part EE
7 of chapter 55 of the laws of 2014, is amended to read as follows:

8 (9) with a crossbow unless such crossbow shall consist of a bow and
9 string, either compound or recurve, [~~that launches a minimum fourteen~~
10 ~~inch bolt, not including point,~~] mounted upon a stock with a trigger
11 that holds the string and limbs under tension until released. The trig-
12 ger unit of such crossbow must have a working safety. The [~~minimum limb~~
13 ~~width of such crossbow shall be seventeen inches, have a~~] minimum peak
14 draw weight of such crossbow shall be one hundred pounds [~~and a maximum~~
15 ~~peak draw weight of two hundred pounds. The minimum overall length of~~
16 ~~such crossbow from buttstock to front of limbs shall be twenty-four~~
17 ~~inches~~].

18 § 3. Subparagraph 9 of paragraph c of subdivision 4 of section 11-0901
19 of the environmental conservation law, as added by section 7 of part EE
20 of chapter 55 of the laws of 2014, is amended to read as follows:

21 (9) with a crossbow unless such crossbow shall consist of a bow and
22 string, either compound or recurve, [~~that launches a minimum fourteen~~
23 ~~inch bolt, not including point,~~] mounted upon a stock with a trigger

EXPLANATION--Matter in italics (underscored) is new; matter in brackets
[-] is old law to be omitted.

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1 that holds the string and limbs under tension until released. The trig-
2 ger unit of such crossbow must have a working safety. The ~~[minimum limb~~
3 ~~width of such crossbow shall be seventeen inches, have a]~~ minimum peak
4 draw weight of such crossbow shall be one hundred pounds ~~[and a maximum~~
5 ~~peak draw weight of two hundred pounds. The minimum overall length of~~
6 ~~such crossbow from buttstock to front of limbs shall be twenty four~~
7 ~~inches]~~.

8 § 4. Paragraph a of subdivision 1, paragraphs a and b of subdivision 8
9 and subdivision 10 of section 11-0907 of the environmental conservation
10 law, paragraph a of subdivision 1 as amended and subdivision 10 as added
11 by section 14 and paragraphs a and b of subdivision 8 as amended by
12 section 16 of part EE of chapter 55 of the laws of 2014, are amended to
13 read as follows:

14 a. Wild deer without antlers or having antlers measuring less than
15 three inches in length shall not be taken unless it is taken (1) by long
16 bow in a special long bow season established in subdivision [3] three of
17 this section, or (2) by muzzle-loading firearm ~~[or crossbow]~~ in a
18 special muzzle-loading firearm season established in subdivision [8]
19 eight of this section, or (3) by long bow in Westchester and Suffolk
20 Counties in a year in which a regular season for deer of either sex is
21 established for such counties, or (4) in a special open season for deer
22 of either sex fixed by regulation pursuant to subdivision [5] five or
23 [7] seven of section 11-0903 of this title, or (5) pursuant to a special
24 antlerless deer license in a special open season for antlerless deer in
25 a tract within a Wilderness Hunting Area fixed by regulation pursuant to
26 subdivision [6] six of section 11-0903 of this title, or (6) pursuant to
27 a deer management permit by a person eligible to take such deer pursuant
28 thereto as provided in section 11-0913 of this title, or (7) pursuant to
29 a permit issued to an eligible non-ambulatory person, pursuant to subdivi-
30 sion [2] two of section 11-0931 of this title, while in possession of
31 a valid license issued by the department which authorizes the holder to
32 hunt big game. Nothing in this subparagraph shall be construed to limit
33 the power of the department to designate by regulation an area or areas
34 of the state consisting of a county or part of a county where such
35 season shall apply and whether the number of such special permits shall
36 be limited.

37 a. In every area identified in column one of the table set forth in
38 subdivision two of this section, except those areas restricted to
39 special seasons for taking deer by longbow only, special open seasons
40 may be established by regulation for taking deer and/or bear, by the use
41 of muzzle-loading firearms, of not less than .44 caliber shooting a
42 single projectile~~[, or by the use of a crossbow,]~~ by the holders of a
43 hunting license with a valid muzzle-loading privilege.

44 b. Such special open season for the Southern Zone shall be for the
45 seven day period immediately preceding the regular open season for deer
46 stated in column two of the table set forth in subdivision two of this
47 section, except that the department may, by regulation, fix such open
48 season in the Southern Zone or any portion thereof to be either the
49 seven days immediately preceding or immediately following the regular
50 open season for deer~~[, provided, however, that any taking of deer or~~
51 ~~bear by the use of a crossbow in a season or special season in which the~~
52 ~~muzzle loader is the only firearm permitted shall succeed the regular~~
53 ~~open hunting season for deer established pursuant to subdivision two of~~
54 ~~of this section]~~.

55 10. Notwithstanding any provision of this chapter, or any prior
56 notwithstanding language in this article, the department may, by regu-

lation, authorize the taking of big game by the use of a crossbow by any licensed person in any big game season in any area [~~designated in items (a), (b), (c), (d), (e), (f), (i), (k) and (l) of paragraph a of subdivision two of this section~~] in which a [~~shotgun or muzzle loader~~] long bow is permitted [~~provided however, that any crossbow use during an archery only season shall only take place during the last fourteen consecutive days of such archery only season in the southern zone provided that such archery only season shall consist of not less than forty-five days and only during the last ten consecutive days of any archery only season in the northern zone provided that such archery only season shall consist of no less than twenty-three days. Any muzzle loading season which occurs at the same time as a special archery season may only occur during times when crossbows are authorized to be used~~].

§ 5. Section 11-0931 of the environmental conservation law is amended by adding a new subdivision 8 to read as follows:

8. a. No person in Westchester, Nassau, or Suffolk county shall discharge a crossbow within five hundred feet of a dwelling house, a farm building or farm structure actually occupied or used, or a school building or playground, public structure, or occupied factory or church.

b. A county not enumerated in paragraph a of this subdivision may opt by local law to be covered by the provisions of such paragraph.

§ 6. This act shall take effect immediately.